3.6- Social Control: Types and Agencies

Learning objectives

- Define the concept of social control and explain its key features and importance in maintaining social order
- Discuss the major types of social control
- Identify the various agencies of social control
- Distinguish between formal and informal agencies of social control

Learning outcomes

- Explain the concept of social control and its necessity for the functioning of society
- Classify social control into formal and informal types and describe the characteristics of each
- Identify various agencies of social control and related them to real life situations
- Discuss various types of social control being used in a different social scenario

3.6- A- Social Control

Introduction

Society is an ensemble of different groups and people living in the same community. Primarily, it is there to ensure the well-being of all and to advance together as a unit. To keep everything functioning in a harmonious way, society manages to balance out the different demands and points of view. All societies have certain rules, This framework remains intact because it possesses rules and systems that facilitate people's compliance.

Sociologists extensively study the ways societies implement social control, which is the control of behaviour. Social control means the control of social behaviour in line with accepted and established norms. Although there have been forms of social control in all societies throughout history, the functioning of social control has changed over time. Social control is extensive and influential; it is mainly responsible for the maintenance of order, discipline, co-operation and for the deterrence of deviant conduct. When necessary, it may also punish wrong doings.

Meaning

The term "social control" was first formally related to sociology by American sociologist E. A. Ross in his seminal book, “Social Control”, published in 1901. In everyday conversation, social control means the different ways a community can govern individual's behaviour. To keep order and organization, people have to be led and affected in such a way that they behave in a socially acceptable manner. It allows individuals to acquire characteristics that are conducive to the smooth functioning of society.

Society is obliged to control its members just enough for it to be able to exist and prosper. Any significant departure from the set standards is regarded as a threat to social wellness. The term social control is used by sociologists when referring to the mechanisms that ensure order and conformity.

The concept of social control involves essentially all the methods that a society implements to guarantee that everyone abides by the rules and meets the expectations like norms. when people are continuously confronted with these rules, they become so much a part of them that help to build their own personality. Through socialization, the child learn the values of their community and society, which provide them with the framework of what is right, normal, and proper behavior.

Societies cannot fully educate their members about the rules and ensure that everyone follows them all the time. A person's personal desires and goals may not completely coincide with what society requires of them. Because of this inconsistency, there will always be a certain amount of deviance, that is, in every group and society there will be those who go beyond the norms or break the rules.

But at the same time, people have qualities such as empathy, friendliness, and a feeling of fairness which stimulate collaboration. These good part helps us cooperate, but it’s too weak to prevent chaos. Therefore, society creates a framework of control like formal and informal ways, to discipline the selfish part and maintain a working or orderly community.

Social control relies on both internal and external methods:

Internal Control (Socialization): Most of the social control is provided indirectly by the socializing process. From the very beginning, we learn and absorb the morality, rules, and values of our culture, so it is very common for us to follow the rules automatically as it is morally correct. Besides, the emotional bonds with the people also support our willingness to conform.

External Control: On top of that, society implements various external means to regularize people's conduct. They are the formal regulations of law and institutions (such as police and courts) on the one hand, and on the other hand, there are very much uniformalised sources such as social approval or disapproval by the family and friends.

There will always be those few people who refuse to obey the rules and will continue to be involved in deviant activities regardless of these control measures. As a consequence, social control is an ongoing and ever-changing endeavour, whose success is judged by the level of social stability attained through the effectiveness of these methods.

Definitions

- E A Ross: “Social control is the system society uses to make its members follow accepted standards of behaviour”.
- Ogburn and Nimkoff: It involves the pressures a society applies to maintain order and uphold established rules.
- Roberts: “Social control refers to the techniques and the strategies for regulating human behaviour in any society.”
- Gillin and Gillin: It includes all forms of persuasion, suggestion, restraint, and even physical force used to make individuals follow approved behaviour.

- MacIver: Social control is the process through which the social system stays together and maintains balance.
- Morirs Janowitz: “Social control focuses on the capacity of a social organisation to regulate itself.”

Nature and Key Features of Social Control

The main natures of social control point out its necessity for social functioning:

- Universality: Social control is a common feature of all human societies. Its presence is an intrinsic condition of collective life; where a society exists, mechanisms of control are invariably in operation.
- Maintenance of Order: The main feature of this is its function to establish and keep social order as well as stability of the system. It achieves this by protecting core social values and normative patterns, thus, it makes the social structure predictable and continuous.
- Internalization of Norms: On the individual level, social control serves to promote those behavioural patterns which are socially acceptable and to reject those which deviate. It is the procedure by which individuals internalize the expectations of society, thus resulting in a well-organized and self-regulating community.

Social control is the implementation of methods by a society to keep the behaviour of people in check and maintain order. It is achieved by motivating people to respect social norms and rules and at the same time, prevent any kind of disruptive or "deviant" behaviour. These are its main features:

1. It regulates behaviour

The essential aim of social control is to instruct human behaviour. It establishes the conduct of good manners to make sure that people behave in a way that is beneficial to society, rather than only looking out for their own impulses, which would result in chaos.

2. It can be Formal or Informal

The different ways that social control has formally and informally operate are:

- ☆ Formal Control: It is concerned with official, planned systems. It also comprises the use of law, the police, judges, and government regulations utilizing punishments (like prison or bribes) to compel adherence to rules.
- ☆ Informal Control: It is guided by the unspoken rules of the social world. This consists of social norms, peer pressure, and family/community expectations. It is implemented through encouragement (praise, inclusion) or condemnation (gossip, humiliation).

3. It is Universal

Social control of some kind has existed in every human society, whether it is primitive or modern. Even though the methods may be hugely different- from the laws based on tribal customs to the present ones- the necessity of behaviour regulation to ensure stability is a universal phenomenon of social life.

4. It is Dynamic and Adaptable

Social control is not unchanging; it varies with time as the morals and values change. Sometimes what used to be considered as deviant is acceptable now, and vice versa. For instance, since perspectives regarding LGBTQ+ rights have altered, both laws and social norms have progressed. Similarly, the issue of cybersecurity has given rise to rules such as data privacy regulations.

5. It maintains social order and Unity

Social control through the establishment of explicit rules and accepted standards, prevents disorder and holds society together. It offers stability to the society where people are aware of their rights and duties. The shared understanding among the members lowers the chances of conflicts and increases the cooperation which is a must for the survival of a society.

6. It is culturally specific

The ways in which social control is practiced in one culture may not be effective in another. In some places, religion is not just the main source of moral guidance but also the controlling factor. While in other places, formal laws and individual rights are the centre of the system. The effectiveness of a certain method is determined by the cultural background taking into consideration social control.

7. It applies to everyone, But can be unequal

Social control is supposed to be for everyone that belongs to a community; in practice, however, we may see this differently. Factors such as money, power, and social position may influence how social control is implemented. As an example, laws are made for everyone, but a person with power might be able to escape punishment much easier than a less privileged one.

8. It balances freedom and Order

Social control, while indispensable for stability, inevitably limits individual freedom to some extent. A community cannot afford to let individuals behave as they wish if they want to ensure the welfare of the collective. For example, one of the rights is freedom of speech, but it does not protect hate speech that leads to violence. That is how a required balance is established between personal liberty and communal security.

9. It uses rewards and Punishments

Social control employs two main instruments to induce compliance:

- ⌘ Rewards (Positive Reinforcement): Making conformity more attractive by utilizing verbal compliments, social approval, promotion, and other benefits.
- ⌘ Punishments (Negative Reinforcement): Halting deviance by creating the fear of undesired consequences, for instance, penalties, isolation from society, or jail.

Need or Purpose of Social Control

Social control is a must to keep order in a society. To do this, society needs to lead and regulate the behaviour of each person so that social norms can be kept and stability maintained. If there were no such control, the organization of society would fall apart.

The ones properly socialized adhere to the accepted norms without being forced- since they do it both out of habit and because they want to be approved by others. Nevertheless, if the socialization process is weak, people may behave in an unexpected manner and, hence, they need to be controlled in order to be put back on track again. The main goal of social control is to ensure the existence of a society that is predictable and orderly. This is done by:

1. Encouraging Conformity: Social control leads people's behaviour to be in harmony with the norms and values that are generally accepted, thus helping to the formation of a society characterized by discipline, unity, and mutual respect.

2. Discouraging Deviance: Social control steps in to stop and, if the case, to punish "deviant" behaviours, i.e., those acts that go against social rules. Societies without social control would be riddled with the abandonment of rules and chaos where instability would be the only thing in power.

Social control is not merely a by-product of society - it is actually the most indispensable element for a society to function and survive. If a group or society desires to accomplish three vital things, it must possess social control:

- Conformity: Essentially, it is about people following rules and behaving in a certain manner.
- Unity: The main function of social control is to unite the group and keep it from disintegrating.
- Continuity: The ultimate function of social control is to keep the society and its way of life alive during the course of time.

Different thinkers have explained the need for social control in the following ways:

1. To preserve the existing social system

One of the most essential needs of social control is to prevent the occurrence of chaos as the stability of society is maintained. In a world without rules and expectations, each person looking out for his own interest could start fights and disorder would reign. Social control is the one which offers the framework (through laws, norms, and institutions) for society to work efficiently and in a safe manner.

Social control maintains the current social structure. A society is its members who are expected to continue the established traditions, in a manner similar to the one their forefathers lived by. Progress, along with its strict enforcement may be somewhat slowed, but disorder would be inevitable without some continuity.

2. To regulate individual behaviour

In order to realize collective objectives and maintain social morals, individuals need to behave according to norms that are accepted by society. If people were to act only on their self-

interests, then there would be a collapse of social order. Social control aims at regulating individual behaviour and making sure that it is consistent with shared social goals and values. It supports communal ambition by turning personal drives into ventures that serve the whole society, which is a must for an organized and efficient one. So, control is necessary for the society to operate and develop.

Social control accomplishes its mission by getting people to abide by the rules of society. It does so by scaring off "deviant" behaviours, which are acts that go against norms and laws, through a sanction system. Such punishment can be a formal one (like the judicial penalty for crimes) or an informal one (like stigmatizing a person for being impolite). By providing clear repercussions, society discourages those behaviours that may injure persons or disturb the community.

3. To ensure obedience to social decisions

Communities come up with rules and make joint decisions based on the idea of maintaining their fundamental values. Through different devices, social control is the one that ensures compliance with rules and decisions.

4. To promote social unity

Social control stimulates participation in the sense of oneness by convincing people to behave in a similar manner, which is expected and predictable, thus facilitated by shared norms. The familiarity with the same conduct creates the feeling of togetherness and solidarity. It achieves this also through the proper management of disputes arising from different sectors, thus hindering the more powerful groups from taking advantage of the weaker ones and ensuring social peace. Without control, unity is not attainable. Social control, by regulating conduct according to shared norms, creates order and binding among individuals.

5. To maintain social solidarity

In a fiercely competitive world, the more robust communities might take advantage of the weaker ones, and the fights may also occur between the groups that are equally powerful. This situation brings about disorder. Social control is the system that discourages antisocial behaviour and ensures the peaceful coexistence of society.

6. To bring about conformity

Essentially, the main purpose of social control is to bring about conformity to the extent that most people adhere to the same rules and standards. Such standardization of behaviour is what makes living in a society predictable and safe. Drastically, when an individual has a significant deviation from the norms that are generally accepted, they are perceived as a threat to the group. Hence society uses sanctions (rewards for conformity, punishments for deviance) to encourage people to stay in line. In brief, Social control is an instrument which encourages people to act in similar and acceptable manners, thus ensuring consistency within the group.

7. To enforce social sanctions

If a person or a character is extremely deviating from the norms that are normally accepted, the general welfare of the group is in danger. Therefore, Sanctions i.e. rewards or punishments are instruments that are used to bring back such behaviour to normal.

8. To prevent cultural maladjustment

The civilizations have different lifestyles, and they keep changing. Not everyone, however, changes at the same speed. There are some people who may find it difficult to adjust to the new situations and they may eventually behave in such a way that is against the new norms. Society is through control system guiding the people and managing the behaviours that are not in line with the new social order. For instance, care for the environment is one of the areas in which new regulations and education have played a vital role in managing changes in attitudes.

Importance of Social Control

One of the conditions that is necessary for the development of any society is that its groups, institutions, and organizations should operate effectively. But although these groups operate effectively, there will always be conflicts that come up in situations where the individuals or groups that are involved in the conflicts will be those which pursue their own interests without thinking of others. Now, the problem of these limited opportunities makes it worse as a result of which dominant groups tend to keep the control over the scarce lifeguards. Moreover, different social divisions and ideologies affect also the society in the sense that they destroy its harmony. Consequently, society should always be in control in order to be able to control these selfish and unifying trends.

It would be almost impossible to keep social balance if there were no appropriate regulations. Social control is a necessary measure in order to decrease crime and to increase social welfare. By making citizens abide by the set rules and values, social control become the main agent of stability and continuity in the social system.

The chief role of social control involves the safeguarding of the present social order and the assurance of its survival. Any society that wants to continue its existence requires that its members will comply with the established framework of norms. Social control provides this service by enforcing these rules from one generation to another. Moreover, it contributes a lot to the survival of cultural traditions and their transmission to coming generations. Traditions are there to protect our heritage and social control encourages people to follow them.

As people assemble in groups, they bring with them different viewpoints, and their personal goal may be different also. Through the suppression of personal motives, social control promotes the realization of unity in the group which is the most important thing for collective interests. In the same manner, it helps obtain the uniformity in thoughts, behaviour, and attitudes, which are the fundamental things for the society to work smoothly.

The factors that influence social unity and cohesion are among those which are controlled by social control. By requiring people to abide by the norms that have been set, social control brings about a uniformity in behaviour which in turn leads to fewer conflicts and greater integration. This collective conformity to a common set of rules and values constitutes not only

a more predictable social environment but also the strengthening of the bonds between members of a group.

Human societies are very diverse in their attitudes, interests, and ideologies, and this diversity, in turn, creates a potential for conflicts that may arise at any time. In modern, highly individualistic societies, this risk is raised because self-interest is often in competition with collective needs. Social control serves as a unifying mechanism among these opposing individual behaviours to safeguard what is in the best interest of the society. By restricting the degree of individual liberty that can be exercised, it keeps the social structure from dropping into the lowest level of anarchy where there is no control over self-interest and as a result, there is chaos and disorder.

Collaboration is the basis for social life, and any group without it is bound to perish. Social control promotes cooperation among people. Besides that, it provides social security as human beings are not capable of living in isolation. Social control, by warding off evil forces, takes care of people and equips them to deal with the society's challenges.

In addition to that, human nature is, most of the time, egotistical and craving for power. While every single one of us desires to have control over others, none of us likes to be controlled. Social control is the one that plays the role of the opposing power in the human drama and it operates without complete dominance or chaos.

Consequences of Social Control

While social control remains a critical element in the upkeep of society and the adherence to norms, it is nevertheless vulnerable to certain defects or anomalies. As a result, social control when wrongly used, overdone, or taken over by certain groups, can become a dysfunctional power, which in turn may lead to adverse effects both to individuals and to the community at large.

1. A tool for holding power over others and exploiting them

One of the possible ways in which social control is used is that it becomes a very influential yet not so easily detected weapon of the hegemonic groups' or individual's exploitation. The real motives of such groups, aiming at public order or welfare, are hidden, while they may use different controlling methods to push their unprofitable political, economic, or social agendas. For instance, a ruling political party through its use of propaganda, and restricting dissent via imposing legal measures can thus perpetuate its power, and on the other hand, a commercial enterprise in turn can make use of such tools as persuasive mass media, embedded marketing to manipulate consumers for profit. Social control in such case examples should be regarded as ceasing the function as a community instrument for collective good but rather transforming into a means of domination.

2. An obstacle to social progress and Creativity

Social control is by its characteristic feature an enforcing one and hence its inescapable tendency to operate as a force for social inertia. When the importance of maintaining the order of the existing society is overemphasized, it naturally follows that the society in question may

lose its innovative capacity, creativity, and constructive social reform potential. One reason for this could be that when issues of traditional norms and values become very common, amongst which the compliance to them is tightly controlled, they are not only capable of hindering the recognized as necessary social changes or even the adaptability but also still going further, they are able to reinforce the status quo even in situations when it may be inefficient, unjust, or outdated.

3. Emotional and Mental health issues of the controlled

The implementation of social control especially in its most coercive aspects may bring to individuals significant psychological problems which is a huge price that needs to be paid. This fact most vividly comes to the surface in total institutions like jails, or psychiatric hospitals where highly controlled and oppressive environments create not only mental tension but also psychological distress of a severe nature.

4. The generation of intergroup conflict or Challenges of societal pluralism

In big, pluralistic societies which are characterized by the presence of different subcultures coming from class, caste, religion, and ethnicity backgrounds, the existence of different normative systems and value orientations is unavoidable. When one or more dominant groups try to impose their standards universally on others, social control starts to be a source of dysfunction. The imposition of a single normative framework on a diverse population may thus result in the rise of social friction, overt intergroup conflict, and the resistance of marginalized groups against their cultural autonomy being eroded.

5. Economic and Resource constraints

The machinery of social control- police, judiciary, correctional facilities, and mental health institutions- puts a substantial fiscal burden on society. The control of deviance is responsible for the consumption of the largest part of societal resources that includes a financial expenditure and human capital. That creates a critical opportunity cost, especially for developing countries. The limited resources that are allocated to social control agencies in these countries are most likely coming from the other vital areas such as economic development, education, and healthcare. This, therefore, puts a practical limit on the scale and intensity of formal control measures that can be carried out.

Conclusion

Sociologists are very interested in the methods society uses to guide people's behaviour, a concept known as social control. Even though the societies have always had some forms of social control, the way it has been working has changed throughout history. The very basic norms and values that guide us have always been there, but the specific rules have been constantly changing.

Modern life with all its industrialization, growing cities, fast transportation, and constant communication has made people move and mix in ways that were never before possible. Hence many traditional values have lost their strength. While the old social rules are disappearing, new ones are emerging and shaping society in new ways.

3.6- B- Types of Social Control

Introduction

Each society employs different ways to regulate the behaviour of its members and keep order. However, societies differ in their methods of control because of differences in culture, social relations, traditions, and systems of governance. In certain instances, society may employ a mixture of rewards and punishments, of formal systems and informal customs so as to influence human behaviour. Sociologists have different classifications of social control as one group of thinkers have decided to focus on the different aspects of control whereas another group on the different working mechanisms. According to various sociologists' classifications, the essential kinds of social control are:

1. Karl Mannheim's Classification

Karl Mannheim distinguished two main categories of social control according to the degree of closeness of control to an individual.

(a) Direct Social Control: Direct social control refers to control that comes from people who are within your personal circle and with whom you have regular interaction. It takes place in your primary groups- small, close-knit circles like your family, friends, neighbours, and classmates. Your parents, teachers, or peers directly influence your behaviour through praise, disapproval, or guidance.

(b) Indirect Social Control: This mode of control results from the bigger and more impersonal forces of society. It is not a particular person who gives you orders but the influence of secondary groups and the society in general. Some of these include customs, traditions, laws, and public opinion, all of which regulate our behaviour in a less personalized and in a more abstract way.

2. Georges Gurvitch's Classification

The sociologist Gurvitch presented a more detailed breakdown of social control:

(a) Organised Social Control: This type of control is exercised through established, formal systems. It operates through official institutions that have set rules, such as a government, a university, or a professional association.

(b) Unorganised Social Control: This is an informal control that originates from culture and everyday life. It is not a planned or formally enforced control but is socially expected. Following traditions, customs, fashion trends, and social symbols are some of the examples.

(c) Spontaneous Social control: The immediate social situation and its unwritten rules give rise to this type of control. This is the pressure to conform with the norms, values, and ideas of the environment that you have come from.

(d) More Spontaneous Social Control: This is the most delicate form of control which is coming from an individual but is still shaped by a group. It refers to the goals, dreams, and decisions

of a person that have been influenced by their social experiences and the aspirations of their community.

3. Kimball Young's Classification

Kimball Young came up with a very simple and practical way to categorize social control based on the method used.

(a) Positive Social Control: Such a method is utilizing mostly the rewards and some encouragements in the process of conformity. A goal is to constantly motivate people to follow social norms making use of positive reinforcement.

Some examples would be:-

- a social recognition, a promotion, an award or a compliment. This is the way individuals are made to desire to behave in socially approved ways.
- A worker being awarded with a better position due to his/her hard work, a student being given a scholarship for good academic achievements, or a person being publicly recognized for doing something good.

(b) Negative Social Control: This method employs repulsion as well as the threat of it to keep from breaking rules. The aim is to avoid the undesired conduct through the creation of negative consequences.

Some examples are: Criticism, fines, imprisonment, social rejection, and public shame. The fear of these negative consequences is what makes individuals want to be in compliance with the rules of society.

4. Hayes's Classification

Hayes divided social control into two main parts;

(a) Control by Sanction

- People who live up to the social values and norms receive some sort of reward.
- Those who violate them get punished.
- This way of doing things depends on the use of approval, disapproval, rewards, or penalties.

(b) Control by Socialisation and Education

- Through both schooling and upbringing, children learn what is acceptable behaviour.
- Social values and norms are not only learned but also internalised gradually.

5. F. E. Lumley's- classification of social control

Lumley identified two categories:

(a) Physical Force Method

- Behaviour is controlled through direct physical means.
- Example: use of force, coercion, or punishment to ensure compliance.

(b) Human Symbol Method

- Individuals are influenced through social and cultural symbols such as:
    - Language
    - Traditions
    - Religion
    - Customs
    - Rituals
- This method changes behaviour without physical force.

6. CH Cooley's Classification

Charles H. Cooley stated that socially recognised controls come in two different forms. These are:

(a) Conscious Control

• Conscious control is holding to deliberately and consciously plan the behaviour which is formed by clear norms.

• Society pulls the strings directly to make people behave in accordance with the goals already accepted.

Example: A junior staff member showing respect to the senior staff.

🔻 (b) Unconscious Control

• Unconscious control is control that happens in a manner which is automatic, thus in a habitual way, and formed through the same customs and traditions that have been followed for ages- e.g., ritual patterns or caste-based marriage norms

• Behaviours are indirectly influenced by the different institutions of society such as religion, customs, and traditions etc.

• People stick to the norms without understanding that they are controlled.

(7) Richard T. Lapiere- Classification of social control

(a) Autocratic control:

Autocratic control is an authority's imposition by the use of power, without any consultation with the people- there is the case of military dictatorships.

(b) Democratic control:

Democratic control is a system based on the elements of participation, persuasion, dialogue, and most importantly, consent whereby the rules are the reflection of the will of the people.

(c) Internal Social Control

Such a control belonging le to the domain of the individual, and the control came from within him/her is characterized as an internal social control. It is a type of social control that belongs to one's conscience or the inner moral compass, which is a value that is learned through socialization and accepted by the individual.

- Operation: By one’s own sense of right and wrong, guilt, or personal responsibility
- Enforcer: One enforces it on oneself.
- Example: Not cheating on a test because of a personal conviction (internal control), rather than fear of being caught (external control).

(8) General Views: Two Broad Forms of Social Control

Social control is usually divided into two main categories:

(a) Formal Social Control

Formal social control or secondary social control, as it is sometimes called, is the main regulatory mechanism, which is used in large-scale, complex societies with secondary group structures. Modern industrial and post-industrial societies serve as good examples of such social formations, which consist of a large number of big, impersonal groups that are goal-oriented, such as political parties, corporations, trade unions, and educational institutions.

In these situations, which are characterized by formal and less intimate relationships, the effectiveness of informal controls such as ridicule, criticism, or gossip is greatly reduced. The anonymity, social and geographic mobility, and normative pluralism (the existence of different and even conflicting values in various groups) that are typical of modern life weaken the force of the primary group sanctions. People have more ways to get out of under the surveillance of any one group, and hence, there must be a system of regulation which is more universally applicable and codified. As a result, societies have recourse to formal agencies of social control to keep the equilibrium.

The means of formal control are:

- ❖ Positive Sanctions: These are official rewards, honours, promotions, and other forms of formal recognition of one's conformity and achievement.
- ❖ Negative Sanctions: These bring together punishments written in the law such as fines, demotion, expulsion, imprisonment, and other legal penalties.

At the community level, this control is most clearly represented by the state's legal machinery which consists of law, the judiciary, the police, and the correctional system. Besides these direct agents of enforcement, formal control is also maintained through less direct, though still highly coordinated, methods like propaganda sponsored by the government and the deliberate use of the mass media to "engineer" public opinion and behaviour.

It is, however, very important to bear in mind that a stark contrast between formal and informal control is just one"

Another point worth mentioning is that informal primary groups (or "cliques") always come into being within the setting of formal organizations. These informal networks can have a strong impact on their members in terms of social control, and they can either facilitate and support the achievement of the organization's formal goals or oppose and restrict them by their influence.

(b) Informal Social Control

Informal control is sometimes termed primary social control because of its significant power in what sociologists call primary groups. These groups, which consist of the family, peer groups, close-knit neighbourhoods, and traditional rural communities, are characterized by their small size, high level of social integration, and intimate, face-to-face relationships based on personal loyalty.

In such closely-knit social milieus, the individual is surrounded by a dense and far-reaching network of social monitoring. One may think of this as a set of concentric circles of control, radiating from the immediate family to the community, thus making sure that no person is completely free from social influence.

The main features of this control method are its impromptu and unplanned character. Formal authorities do not hand down sanctions; instead, the group's spontaneous collective reaction to deviant conduct is the one that brings about the sanctions. The treated informal sanctions may include:

- Verbal Expressions: Ridicule, gossip, and direct criticism.
- Social Condemnation: Opprobrium, or the expression of vehement public disgrace.
- Exclusion: Ostracism, a condition wherein an individual is socially shunned or separated from the group.
- Physical Coercion: There is a possibility that in some cases, informal control might also include the use of physical force.

These informal sanctions derive their effectiveness chiefly from the features of the primary group. Due to the strong interpersonal ties, the absence of anonymity, and the limited number of alternative social groups, an individual cannot easily take the group's disapproval lightly. Fame, reputation, or membership are things that, if lost, become a strong motivation for one to conform to the norm.

The mechanisms of informal control are most evident in traditional societies where primary relations are dominant; however, they still have a significant impact in modern, complex societies. In these societies, they are efficient in secondary groups such as voluntary associations, professional organizations, clubs, and trade unions, where they help to introduce and maintain internal discipline and achieve organizational goals without constantly depending on formal rules and procedures.

Conclusion

The existence of different forms of social control indicates that social order is not upheld by a single authority but rather through a complex interplay of both the clearly visible rules and the

subtle, unwritten norms of everyday life. These views collectively assert that the behaviour of an individual is always influenced by a combination of explicit societal rules and the implicit, powerful expectations that come with social interaction. It clearly shows that our behaviour is influenced by a wide range of factors, from formal institutions to our everyday personal experiences.

3.6- C- Agencies of Social Control

Introduction

Agencies are the instruments by which social control is exercised. The phrase "agency" means the groups, organizations, and authorities that are responsible for the enforcement of social norms and the management of control in a regular and effective way. These agencies are the ones that make decisions about what is to be implemented and what is not. Social systems use a multitude of agencies to ensure social control, their particular modes depending on the level of the society's structural complexity. Some of these agencies are extremely codified, institutionalized systems while others are subtle normative influences that guide people's behaviour. Generally, they are two main groups of social control mechanisms - formal and informal ones.

I. Formal Agencies of Social Control

Formal social control involves tightly defined, codified rules that are enforced by state institutions that have been specially created for this purpose. It is most easily seen in complex societies with a political organization of some kind.

1. Law and the State Apparatus

Laws are the official, written rules made by a government which set the limits of human behaviour that is deemed acceptable and those that are not. Law is the most forceful and institutionalized element of formal social control. Law is basically the most potent tool of formal social control. Rooted in society's customs and mores law is formally codified reflecting community's established notions of justice and morality. It holds control over people through official and organized methods, e.g.

Sources of Law include:

- **Custom**
- **Religion**
- **Equity**
- **Judicial decisions**
- **Scientific commentaries**
- **Legislation**

❖ Laws (Legislation) :- The legal system- which, besides laws, includes courts and judges- is the main agency for formal control. It furnishes a regulated procedure for settling conflicts, penalizing lawbreakers, and defending the rights of citizens. Provision of definite legal consequences (such as fines or imprisonment) works as a strong deterrent against deviant behaviour. Law is a generally binding external conduct rule enforced by a sovereign authority. It is binding on all members of society and has to be complied with.

Major things concerning law:

- Law promotes fairness by being uniform and binding on everyone
- Infringement of law results in sanctions

- Law is more ancient than State enforcement
- It was at first derived from the practices of families, tribes, and clans
- The customs that were practiced continuously and without interruption across generations obtained authority and made early law

❖ Police and Armed Forces:- Police are the primary agents of law enforcement at the local level. Their role is to ensure public safety, prevent and solve crimes, and arrest those who violate the law. Their presence and activities are a permanent and conspicuous demonstration of the state's power to impose its rules.

However, the army is a strictly controlled agency, which comes into action in case of an extreme situation, like a war, national emergencies, or complete breakdown of civil order. Although its primary function is to protect the country from outside threats, it may be employed domestically to regain the lost peace if the police are overpowered.

❖ Judiciary (Courts):- Courts are the interpreter of laws and the decision maker of the disputes.

❖ Correctional system (Prisons):- Prisons, juvenile detention centers, and probation systems exist for punishing, deterring, and rehabilitating offenders. By taking away lawbreakers from the community, these places reduce the risk of further harm. They, however, also intend to change inmates through programs like vocational training and therapy, thus facilitating their return to the community as law-abiding citizens.

The characteristics of law as a control mechanism are:

- ➢ Proscriptive Function: To suppress and penalize behaviour that is considered harmful to both individuals and social order such as criminal activities.
- ➢ Prescriptive Function: To regulate social interactions and at the same time bind people to respect the rights of others thus ensuring cooperation and the general welfare of society.

Key features:-

- State-sanctioned authority:- state has legitimate authority over a specific territory and all the people living in it
- Explicit and written nature:- The state's operation is based on very clear and well-defined written laws.
- Principle of universal application: to all citizens, and the

❖ Predetermined punishments: People comply with state rules either because they consider those rules to be their advantage or because they are aware that breaking them will result in punishment under the law.

According to Maclver and Page, law is the set of rules that the state implements, thus making it the protector of society. The state acts as a formal and organized system of control. It preserves order by means of laws, the police, the judiciary, jails, the military, and intelligence agencies. It has the power to suppress those who disobey or challenge it. Besides that, modern

legislation is extended to cover the economic and social sectors as well, whereby it promotes uniformity and mitigates systemic inequalities. Simultaneously, the state takes care of the welfare of its citizens and provides for their employment and livelihood.

❖ Coercion

Coercion is about the actual use or threat of physical force to change behaviour, and it is the last resort that the state has. Employing force or coercion has been one of the earliest methods of social control. Societies throughout the history have been using different levels of force against their deviants and have had to deal with them. Although violence is generally frowned upon, the state is the only one that can legally use force to keep order.

Still, in a majority of cultures, mainly in Indian tradition, it has been considered that using too much force is not very good. Politically, Indian moral principles are more inclined towards nonviolence or just a slight use of violence.

Historical examples:

• Ashoka's reign was the most notable example of a government that completely abandoned the usage of force in its policies.

• Mahatma Gandhi made the nonviolent approach the strongest weapon in the fight against British colonial rule.

The penal laws in modern societies are being continuously revised to become more humane. Unjustified violence very often results in anger and desire for revenge rather than rehabilitation and therefore is less effective as a long-term way of social control.

Coercion is the last resort to be used against the antisocial behaviours that disrupt the social order, to protect groups of people who are at risk of being exploited by those who have more power, and to keep the socio-political system stable. When criminal behaviour is extreme to the point, for example, of robbery, murder, or organized crime, and normative controls have failed, then the police should be allowed to quickly and forcibly restore order and law enforcement take over the legal mandates and enforce them.

2. Educational Institutions

Social control through education reforms is a major theme presented in the paper. The authors argue successfully that the main purpose of education, either formal or informal, is knowledge transfer along with skills and values. A common misconception that people hold is that once schooling is over learning is finished too. Continuous learning is a lifelong process that equips individuals with different skills and attitudes in their roles both as members of the group and as independent persons.

According to Gillin and Gillin, education contributes to social control by developing intelligence and strengthening the influence of customs, traditions, and morals.

As the main source of socialization, education can be referred to as the formal process through which the cultural heritage of a society is handed down from one generation to another. Socialization through education changes the young in line with the six major aspects of the

dominant social system: values, beliefs, and behavioural norms of the prevailing society. By education individuals learn that i.e. to talk with friends, to behave well or with elders, to respect parents, teachers and members of the community take care of oneself, follow customs and communicate with people in different situations. Self-control is another development of education.

Besides this, by helping individuals to think rationally and by giving them through education a moral point of view, social control (conformity to external standards) and self-control (internalization of those standards) are cultivated. Social vision of a community changes from the individual and their personal interests to the well-being of the society as a whole. Education by addressing social realities equips the people to become socially responsible citizens. It puts human behaviour to use reason and also analytical thinking skills are improved. Education also equips individuals with the power to endure life's hardships. To sum up, education transforms human qualities and characters. So, it is a significant human behavioural force that guides and regulates human behaviour throughout life.

II. Informal Agencies of Social Control

Informal social control is essentially the regulation of behaviour through unspoken norms, values, and social pressures, all of which people learn and accept through their upbringing. These control mechanisms are everywhere and they govern the details of people's daily lives.

1) Family

Family is the most elementary and principal source of social control. It is the tiniest social community which comprises the people linked by the relationship of kinship. A generally formed family consists of two adult partners of opposite sex married according to societal norms and their unmarried children. Also, the family can be described as a social group living together and sharing the expenses and the fruits of their labor, as well as reproduction. It is a universal concept—there is no society without the family. Families accomplish two vital functions:

- Socialization: The family is a child's first school where they learn the basic values, beliefs, and behaviours of their culture.
- Regulation: The family establishes laws that its members have to obey. It prepares the children for society's requirements and through its power it leads them to the right way of conduct.

Parents control their kids' conduct by instructing them about what is right and what is wrong. The family teaches social values and is a constant source of support for individuals throughout their lifespan. Being a primary group, it heavily influences children's habits and growth as parents are the first to impact them. The family has a big hand in morality by doing this through many of its members. Values like sacrifice, tolerance, cooperation, kindness, honesty, and hard work are some of the things that kids learn in the family. Children are brought up by parents or

guardians who love and take care of them. By making certain relationships and obligations binding, the family leads its members to socially constructive behaviour.

The family does the most important jobs such as controlling sexual behaviour through socially approved mating, fair division of labor between men and women, raising children in a loving environment, and passing essential values to the next generation. It is the first and most important agent of socialization. A human being enters the world in a family and, in most cases, leaves it as well. The impact of the family is not even limited to life, but it is there before birth and after death.

2. Normative Structures

These three ideas lie at the heart of informal social control because they provide the basis for expected behaviour.

⌘ Norms

Social norms are basically the unwritten rules or standards of behaviour that are expected from members of a certain society. Norms stem from social institutions and perform the role of the measure to which behaviour is regulated. They restrict individuals from going beyond cultural goals set and at the same time, give them guidance for their actions. They also shape individuals' attitudes as well as knitting the society. Norms act as a "blueprint" for people to follow outlining the basic criteria for behavioural choices while still allowing some freedom. Norms contribute to society's stability as well as influencing our attitudes. Breaching a norm may expose one to punishments such as social rejection, mockery, or even, more serious penalties.

⌘ Values

Values are the shared ideas of the culture concerning what is good, right, and important. They are the characteristics or achievements that society asks its members to pursue. e.g., success, honesty, or freedom. Values are the platform upon which norms are constructed.

⌘ Customs

Customs represent the time-tested, traditional behaviour modes that have been inherited through the generational line. These are the practices which are done most of the time automatically, because they are indelibly fixed in the culture. People breaching a custom get the social disapproval thrown at them. Customs are very gradual in their change and do not have the ability to adjust to the new situations easily. The law makers have to co-exist with customs, as laws that overlook them are usually inefficient. Nevertheless, a lot of customs nowadays that are still around have almost lost their power as a means of control in the society, because our world is changing really fast.

According to Kingsley Davis, customs are those social practices which have been consistent through the generations and are done mainly out of tradition and precedent. They are so deeply rooted in the society that they cover practically everything from the way we dress and consume to the rites and ceremonies and function as the self-regulated rules of conduct.

⌘ Folkways

Folkways are the daily customs and habits of a certain group of people, for example, the use of fork and knife during the meal or the way of greeting elders. They are very informal, casual and simple rules that are regarded as "the usual" way of doing things. Breaking a folkway is not considered a serious crime, however, the violator might be judged as impolite or strange.

Folkways are a key instrument of social control and they originate from the repeated social practices. They signify the socially approved ways of behaving within a community, although sometimes they do not have a moral side. Folkways determine the traditional aspects of appropriate behaviour in a certain society or group, and people tend to follow them without even realizing that they do.

Generally, these practices are handed down from one generation to another through the process of socialization, mainly from parents to their children. Folkways are informal and are not supported by law, still, they strongly affect human conduct as society is always abiding by them. By doing this, folkways become a very efficient instrument for the guidance and regulation of social behaviour.

⌘ Mores

Mores are norms that are given strong moral significance because they are considered to be the main factors for the welfare and the integrity of the group. Mores are social norms that a group thinks are fundamental for its existence and survival. They serve as morality in the society, pointing out the right and the wrong. The infringements of mores cause the most vehement social condemnation and may, to a large extent, bring about the loss of an individual's reputation as well as his social position. Normally, mores are the rules which are not written down and the community enforces them through social pressure rather than by the official laws. There are two kinds of each:

- Positive mores are the "do's" giving you the directions of your behaviour like "be honest" or "respect your parents.
- Negative mores are the "don'ts" that disallow specific actions, as in "don't steal" or "don't lie."

Mores are considered to be one of the most influential types of informal social control. People refrain from violating mores as they are afraid that this may harm the social group. In many instances these particular unspoken moral codes can even have a greater impact than the official laws.

3. The Neighbourhood

The neighbourhood not only provides support to the family but also strengthens the social control that the family exercises. In such close-knit communities, control is usually manifested in the form of informal social norms. These moral rules that are not written down are generally kept alive and enforced by the community members themselves especially the older or more established ones who are the bearers of local traditions. Neighbourhoods facilitate and empower the influence of families. Conventionally, elders and the lifestyle of the community

are the guides for what is considered proper behaviour. Thanks to shared values and covert supervision, neighbours are the ones who determine the behaviour of individuals, especially in heavily interwoven communities.

4. Religion and Morality

- Religion: As a belief system revolving around a supernatural entity, religion is undoubtedly a major informal control measure. It governs the morals of people through a divine moral code and at the same time it assures reward(s) (i.e., Heaven) for good deeds and threatens punishment(s) (i.e., Hell) for bad ones. The religious teachings, taboos, and commandments not only keep the believers in check but also solidify the dominant values of society by frequently inducing inner sanctions like guilt in conjunction with the dread of divine punishment.

Socially accepted beliefs strongly influence human behaviour. People follow rules because they believe that:

- Obedience brings approval and rewards, while disobedience results in punishment.
- A divine or supernatural force keeps track of one's good and bad deeds.
- The soul is immortal, and this life is a result of the past (karma).
- Good deeds take one to heaven, whereas bad ones to hell.
- Righteous conduct brings glory to one's family and ancestors.

Such beliefs not only require people to behave responsibly but also, they strengthen the moral and spiritual side of their characters thus acting as a powerful tool of social control which is still very effective even when formal laws are not present.

- Morality: Although closely associated with religion and possessing the same characteristics, morality is the system of ideas about right and wrong derived from religion as well as from other sources. Behavioural concepts such as honesty, integrity, and compassion, direct the conduct of a person's through their own conscience. Whereas religion uses fear of God as its means, morality on the other hand uses an internalized sense of duty and ethical responsibility derived from personal experience.

5. Public Opinion and Propaganda

- Public Opinion: This is the aggregation of the attitudes and evaluations of the community concerning political, social problems and local events that matter to them. These opinions exert a strong influence on individuals, pushing them to conform. The motivation for social acceptance and the apprehension of social criticism encourage people to bring their actions in line with the dominant public opinion.

In a democratic society, public opinion is a very effective method of social control. Most people want to avoid being criticized or condemned by others. As a consequence, they are inclined to modify their conduct so that it is in line with the shared opinions and feelings of the public. The wish to be accepted and the avoidance of social criticism make public opinion a strong, albeit informal, force for ensuring conformity.

Policy makers in all forms of governance are very attentive to public opinion. The success or failure of their plans, projects, or policies is often contingent on whether the public opinion is supportive or not. On the other hand, public opinion is not always logical and may even sometimes be at odds with legal or constitutional provisions. It is not the voice of every person or even a majority, but still, it is important because it brings influence to the collective interests of the group.

On one hand, the mass media-political, and religious leaders, educational institutions, and political parties-are the major channels that help in setting up public opinion. Public opinion coming through these channels shows the people's wishes and attitudes, thus guiding governance and socializing the society to peaceful coexistence, hence serv-ing as another effective means of social control.

- Propaganda: Propaganda is a leading and efficient method of social control in the current society. It manipulates human conduct by giving information on what is considered morally right or wrong and it also allows organizations or institutions to obtain feedback from social groups. Propaganda is an intentional, structured, and systematic attempt to influence people's minds, beliefs, decisions, and behaviours in a certain way.

  It is true that in some cases propaganda is used to manipulate public opinion by showing biased or exaggerated facts; nevertheless, it can also perform positive roles in the society. Examples of such include educating the public about the presence of social evils, introducing them to current issues and government programs. The communication of the messages of influential leaders to the public is also done through propaganda. Some of the common channels are newspapers, magazines, books, radio, television, cinema, exhibitions, fairs, festivals, and public meetings.

  Essentially, propaganda acts as a major means through which human behaviour is directed and regulated if it is employed successfully.

6. Sanctions

Sanctions are not an agent on their own, rather, they are the operatives that execute all kinds of social control.

- Positive Sanctions: These are the incentives for conforming behaviour and entail such things as praise, awards, promotions, and social recognition.
- Negative Sanctions: These punishments for deviant behaviour and may be informal reactions like gossip, ridicule and social exclusion as well as formal measures such as fines, imprisonment, and capital punishment.

Miscellaneous Cultural Norms

Some other less obvious informal control methods are:

- Fashion: It is the main tool that controls aesthetic expression by allowing individual variation to a certain extent, which is socially and culturally defined. It not only limits creativity to a certain degree but also assures a certain level of uniformity.

- ✡ Rites, Rituals, and Ceremonies: These organized, and often repetitive, practices form the framework of social life, serve as markers of major changes (e.g., marriage, graduation), and help support collective bonds and values.
- ✡ Etiquette: A very definite conduct code that governs interaction between people thus making the behaviour in different settings (e.g., a formal dinner, a funeral) expected and respectful.
- ✡ Art: Art (including music, literature, and painting) is a less direct form of social control.
    - o Channelling Instincts (Sublimation):- Art offers people a socially acceptable outlet for their deep-seated feelings and instincts (like aggression, love, or sorrow). Rather than individuals deliberately performing these instincts in a disordered manner, they can channel these into the production or consumption of art. This is the process known as sublimation.
    - o Communicating Values:- Besides this, art is a subtle vehicle that facilitates the transmission of the values, morals, and ideals of a culture, thus shaping people's thinking and feeling even when they are not aware of it. Art reaches out to the human emotions, and by moulding those, it becomes a very potent instrument of social control. Various forms of art such as sculpture, painting, weaving, architecture, clothing design, pottery, literature, music, and dance have a significant impact on the attitudes and behaviour of people. Artistic expressions have the power to motivate individuals to engage in socially beneficial activities while at the same time they can dissuade them from exhibiting undesirable behaviour.
    - o Indirect Socialization: The major part of this influence occurs behind people's back. Art is a subtle "trainer" that prepares individuals by demonstrating what is considered beautiful, heroic, or moral in their culture, thus leading them to internalize these values. For example, national songs and anthems serve to bind the citizens together and raise patriotism. In a similar manner, cartoons and caricatures can convey vital social messages that remain indelibly stamped on one's memory. In this manner, art serves not only as a means of preserving the cultural legacy and a mirror of human progress but also as a guide through emotional influence.

❖ Ideology

An ideology is a set of interrelated beliefs and values shared by a society that essentially determines the way social thinking a society "works". Ideologies like religious doctrines or political ideas such as national unity, form the basis of a common worldview and community feeling. This unified outlook encourages people to behave in ways that are consonant with the group's ethos.

Social ideals are the main factors that lead human behaviour. The life and works of great people become the pattern for others to imitate. The example can be taken of the messages and the leadership of personalities like Mahatma Gandhi, Jawaharlal Nehru, and Subhash Chandra Bose that deeply moved the Indian people and made them feel ardently patriotic.

People put an enormous value on such ideals as they offer a moral compass for society. A country like India where people follow different religions, speak different languages, and come from different backgrounds, the universally recognized ideal of "unity in diversity" has still been the main factor behind people's peaceful coexistence.

Conclusion

Agencies of social control refer to the specific groups, institutions, and systems that a society employs to teach and enforce its norms, values, and rules. Their task is to guarantee that people behave according to the expected standards, which is a way of maintaining social order, stability, and unity. These agencies are present at every level of society and they work together to shape our behaviour from childhood to adulthood.

The official systems like the government and the judiciary that, among others, put into practice formal laws and regulations. They are the ones who can take direct action to impose consequences, such as fines and jail terms, on lawbreakers. Schools and workplaces, as organized settings, also have formal rules for handling discipline and cooperation. They employ a system of rewards (good grades, promotions) and penalties to motivate the desired behaviour.

Even from a very young age, the guidance comes from the closest people to us - our family and friends. They teach us what is right and what is wrong using informal methods. More extensive cultural forces like public opinion, moral beliefs, and the media also contribute to our behaviour. They determine what we consider to be acceptable or desirable and do so most of the time through discreet messages and social pressure.

All these different institutions and influences together create the network of agencies of social control. These agencies are the institutional and organizational structures through which a society carries out regulation. They are the entities- ranging from primary groups to formal state bodies- which have the authority to implement and enforce societal norms.

Check Your Progress

MCQ

1. The term social control primarily introduced to sociology by

A) EA Ross B) Mac Iver

C) Roberts D) Parson

2. The book “Social control” authored by

A) Mac Iver B) EA Ross

C) GH Mead D) Jean Piaget

3. Social control refers to

A) Political power over citizens B) Government regulation only

C) Economic equality in society D) Mechanism that ensure order and conformity

4. Who defined "Social control is the system society uses to make its members follow accepted standards of behaviour"?

A) E A Ross B) Mac Iver
C) Morirs Janowitz D) Sigmund Freud

5. Karl Mannheim classified social control into …….

A) Direct and Indirect social control

B) Conscious and Unconscious social control

C) Positive and Negative social control

D) Organised and Unorganised social control

6. Find out an example for indirect social control

A) Family B) Friends
C) Classmates D) Customs

7. This type of social control is exercised through formalised institutional system, it is known as

A) Organised social control B) Indirect social control

C) Spontaneous social control D) Negative social control

8. Which of the following type of social control not proposed by Gurvitch?

A) Organised social control B) Unorganised social control
C) Spontaneous social control D) Conscious social control

9. It is a method of social control through provide promotion, award or compliments, it is known as

A) Positive social control B) Organised social control

C) Negative social control D) Unconscious social control

10. CH Cooley classified social control into

A) Conscious and Unconscious social control

B) Organised and Unorganised social control

C) Positive and Negative social control

D) Direct and Indirect social control

11. Which of the following is a formal means of social control?

A) Neighbourhood B) Religion

C) Law D) Tradition

12. Informal social control is exercised by

A) Government B) Peer group

C) Law D) Bureaucratic organization

13. Religion is considered as a …….. form of social control

A) Informal B) Formal

C) Autocratic D) Coercive

14. The primary aim of social control is to …….

A) Maintain social order and stability

B) Help to hold power by small group

C) Create critical opportunity cost

D) All of the above

Short note

1. Define social control
2. Define formal social control with example
3. Define informal social control
4. List out any four agencies of social control
5. Discuss direct and indirect social control

Short essay

1. Explain nature and key features of social control.
2. Explain formal and informal types of social control.
3. "Social control is necessary for smooth functioning of society", Elaborate this statement with suitable example

Essay

1. Define social control and explain its major types with examples.
2. Discuss in detail the formal and informal agencies of social control.
3. Analyse the importance of social control in maintaining social stability and preventing deviance.

MCQ Answers

1. A) EA Ross
2. B) EA Ross
3. D) Mechanism that ensure order and conformity
4. A) E A Ross
5. A) Direct and Indirect social control
6. D) Customs
7. A) Organised social control
8. D) Conscious social control
9. A) Positive social control
10. A) Conscious and Unconscious social control
11. C) Law
12. B) Peer group
13. A) Informal
14. A) Maintain social order and stability

****